

Sex, Relationships, and Communication

DOMINANCE AND POWER PLAYS IN RELATIONSHIPS

Self determination theory

Self-Determination Theory (SDT) is a theory of motivation and personality that focuses on understanding the factors that drive human behavior and lead to personal growth, well-being, and fulfillment.

Self determination theory

- SDT proposes that there are three fundamental psychological needs that are essential for human well-being and optimal functioning:
 - **Autonomy:** The need to feel in control of one's own actions and decisions, rather than feeling controlled by external forces.
 - **Competence:** The need to feel capable and effective in one's pursuits and endeavors.
 - **Relatedness:** The need for meaningful connections, relationships, and a sense of belonging with others.

Self determination theory

- In relationships, individuals may be motivated to interact with their partners because of:
- **Intrinsic Motivation:** Engaging in activities or behaviors within the relationship because they are personally meaningful, enjoyable, or aligned with one's values and desires.
- **Extrinsic Motivation:** Engaging in activities to gain rewards, approval, or to avoid conflict or negative consequences.'
- **Amotivation:** A lack of motivation or interest in the relationship, which can lead to disengagement and apathy.

Self determination theory

SDT emphasizes the importance of fostering **intrinsic motivation** in relationships.

- When individuals feel autonomously motivated to engage with their partner, they are more likely to experience a deeper sense of connection, satisfaction, and fulfillment.

A relationship environment that supports autonomy, competence, and relatedness is more likely to nurture intrinsic motivation and foster overall well-being.

- Controlling or coercive behaviors, on the other hand, can undermine these basic psychological needs.

Self determination theory

When individuals experience autonomy, competence, and relatedness within their relationships, they are more likely to report higher levels of relationship satisfaction, intimacy, and overall well-being.

SDT suggests that individuals in healthy relationships are able to balance their need for autonomy with a desire for emotional closeness and connection.

- This involves respecting each other's independence while also nurturing the bonds of the relationship.

Power and influence in parent-child relationships

Parents need power over children, especially when they are young.

5 general parenting styles

Power and influence in parent-child relationships

- **1. Authoritarian:** demanding and nonresponsive (the dictator)
 - Allow for little open dialogue between parent and child and expect children to follow a very strict set of rules and expectations.
 - Usually rely on harsh punishment to demand obedience or teach a lesson.

Power and influence in parent-child relationships

- **2. Permissive:** undemanding and responsive (often called “indulgent” parenting)
- Parent avoids confrontation
- Few rules for child’s behavior and general lack of structure
- More interested in a “friend” relationship than a parental relationship with child
- May attempt to bribe child with large rewards.

Permissive parenting example



Power and influence in parent-child relationships

- **3. Authoritative:** demanding and responsive (the mentor)
 - Parents have high expectations for their children, but temper these expectations with understanding and support.
 - Structure for child's life (e.g., consistent bedtime, household rules)
 - Clear expectations for child's behavior
 - Open communication between parent and child

Power and influence in parent-child relationships

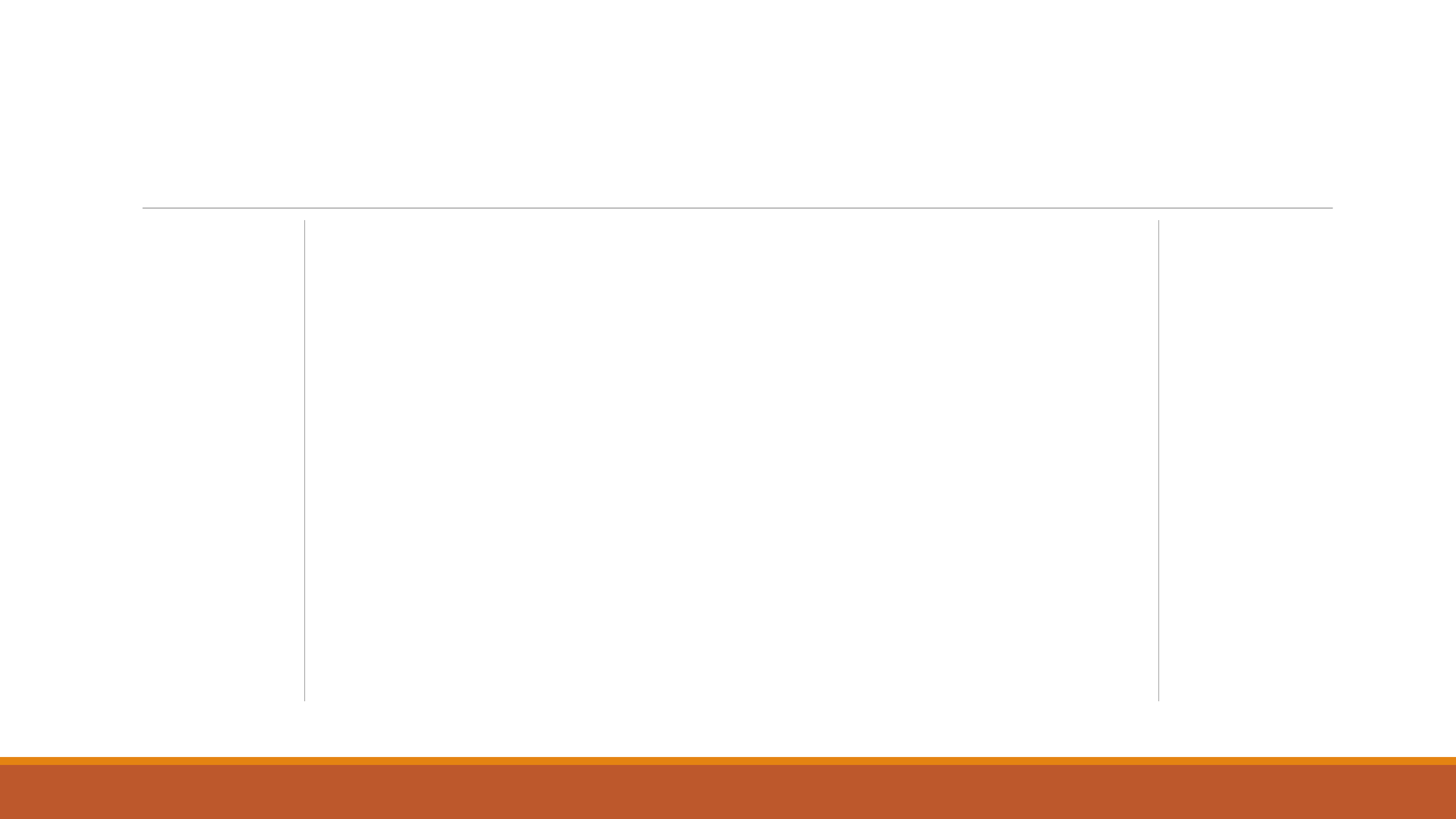
- **4. Neglectful:** Not responsive, not demanding (often called “absent parenting”)
- - Uninvolved in the child’s life
 - Provides very little guidance
 - Provides very little support
 - Indifferent to child’s needs

Power and influence in parent-child relationships

- **5. Over-involved:**
 - Makes almost all decisions for the child
 - Over-schedules child
 - Is hesitant to let child make mistakes (and learn from their mistakes)

Power and influence in parent-child relationships

Authoritative parenting is generally believed to create the healthiest environment for a child and fosters a positive relationship between parent and child.



Power and Influence in Parent-Child Relationships

Separation and individuation:

- a transition point during which teenagers distance themselves from parents.

Separation and individuation

- power struggles and increased conflict between parents and children
- Quality of communication between parents and adolescents typically decreases for a period of time and then recovers.
- The character of the recovered communication is more adult-like.
- Level of closeness between parents and adolescents may also decrease for a period of time.
 - But then also typically recovers.

Separation and individuation

- more reliance on peers
- Peers may become more influential than parents for a period of time.

Separation and individuation

- a renegotiation of rules and privacy boundaries
 - To reflect the child's age and maturity
- parent-adolescent conflict is normal.
- necessary realignments of relationship roles
- this constructive process is most likely to occur when conflicts are neither extreme nor persistent and when they arise in a relationship characterized by warmth and closeness.

The teenage brain

By now, you know I love the brain

- Importance of sleep
 - Growth hormones
 - Delayed release of melatonin in teens
- When does the brain stop developing?
 - Pre-frontal cortex
- Why is it important to LEARN in the teenage years?
 - Synaptic pruning

The teenage brain



Power in marriage

“Traditional” marriages

- one partner makes most decisions; roles are highly specified
 - in heterosexual marriages, by gender.
- Power is imbalanced (one partner has most of the power)

Power in marriage

Egalitarian marriages

- “peer marriages”
- true partnerships
- based on joint decision making
- shared responsibility for finances and household tasks
- power much more evenly distributed
- use of direct requests and bargaining as a verbal influence strategies
- use of compromise and collaboration as conflict styles

Egalitarian marriages



Power in marriage

Although some people are happy in “traditional” marriages, research shows that egalitarian marriages seem to offer the best chance for intimacy and happiness

Transgressions

Relational transgressions

- occur when individuals break implicit or explicit relational codes of conduct or upset relational expectations.
 - Rules
 - Expectations

Relational transgressions – three common

1. Insensitivity to partner's feelings or needs.

2. Deception

3. Infidelity

Transgressions

- Transgressions often result in hurt feelings.
 - Hurt feelings tend to occur in relational contexts
 - Although strangers and acquaintances can cause hurt feelings, the most intense experiences of hurt feelings tend to come from close friends, family members, and romantic partners.

Hurt feelings

Three variables predict intense hurt feelings:

- 1. Ability to respond
 - When people feel like they **lack the ability to respond** to a hurtful event, their hurt is usually intensified.

Hurt feelings

- 2. Perceived intentionality
 - When people feel that a relational partner did something **on purpose** to hurt them, their hurt is usually intensified.

Hurt feelings

- 3. Degree to which hurt feelings were expected
 - When hurt feelings are **unexpected**, they tend to be most intense.

Deception

- Occurs when people *intentionally* manage messages so that a receiver will understand something in a way that the sender thinks is false.
- Deceptions are common in relationships.
- Deceptions are common in everyday interactions.
 - Up to 25% of daily interactions involve deception.

Five types of deception

- **1. Lies:** the information given is opposite or clearly different from what the deceiver perceives as the truth.

2. Equivocation: the information given is indirect, evasive, and/or ambiguous.

- Q: “Do you like my girlfriend?”
- A: “She’s very pretty!”

Five types of deception

- **3. Concealment:** important information about an issue is *left out*.
- **4. Understatement:** certain details of an issue are *downplayed*.
- **5. Exaggeration:** information is overstated; details are sometimes added

Why do people engage in deception?

Five common reasons

- 1. Maintaining a relationship
 - Avoid hurting a partner's feelings
 - Avoid conflict
 - Preserve relationship

Why do people engage in deception?

Five common reasons

- 2. Managing face needs – for both themselves and their partner
 - Enhance or protect self-image
 - Shield self from embarrassment or criticism

Why do people engage in deception?

Five common reasons

- 3. Managing dialectical tensions
 - Example: autonomy/connection: deceiving a partner to spend time alone.
 - Example: openness/closed-ness: deceiving a partner to keep information private

Why do people engage in deception?

Five common reasons

- 4. Establishing relational control
 - Inducing guilt to manipulate a partner
 - Acting like you have better relational alternatives
 - Pretending feelings of love are not as deep as they really are

Why do people engage in deception?

Five common reasons

- 5. Continuing deception
 - Maintaining established lies.

Can we tell when our partner is deceiving us?

Maybe.

- However, deception detection accuracy is generally low (50% to 60% accuracy)

Can we tell when our partner is deceiving us?

Yes:

- Advantages of relational closeness – helps us detect deception
 - behavioral familiarity
 - We know how our partner typically behaves.
 - informational familiarity
 - We have information about our partner.

Can we tell when our partner is deceiving us?

No:

- Disadvantages of relational closeness – hinders our ability to detect deception
- the truth bias
 - A tendency to judge more messages as truths than lies when liking is present.
- Partner's behavioral control
 - Partner's ability to control guilty behaviors to appear truthful.

Deception in relationships

Is deception in relationships always bad?

- No.

Deception in relationships

Positive deceptions:

In certain situations *that do not relate directly to the relationship or one partner's view of the other*, deception may help couples avoid arguments and hurt feelings.

Deception in relationships

- Positive deceptions:
- EXAMPLE:
 - Q: “Do you like my new haircut? I really like it a lot.”
 - A: “It looks great!” (you do not like it).

Deception in relationships

Positive deceptions:

Positive illusion

- “You are the most beautiful and sexy woman I have ever seen.”
- Exaggeration
- Some idealization of partners is a key part of relationship maintenance.

Deception in relationships

Negative deceptions:

- Deceptions about topics that have a significant negative impact on the relationship (relationship-focused), or one partner's view of the other (self-focused).
- Examples:
- *Infidelity, addiction, financial issues

Deception in relationships

- Negative deceptions
 - When people perceive their partners as dishonest, they report less relational satisfaction and commitment.
 - Deception is a leading cause of conflict and breakup in relationships.

4 types of infidelity

1. Sexual infidelity

- occurs when someone engages in sexual activity outside of her/his committed relationship
- 20% to 40% of dating/cohabitating relationships are marked by sexual infidelity.
 - Self-reported data

4 types of infidelity

How common is sexual infidelity among married couples?

- GSS 2019 survey:
 - Have you had sex with someone other than your spouse while married?
 - 17.5% of married individuals said “yes.”
- The most recent data suggest that rates of sexual infidelity among heterosexual men and heterosexual women is very similar.

4 types of infidelity

2. Emotional infidelity

- occurs when someone is emotionally attached to or “in love with” a potential rival
 - May or may not have a sexual component

4 types of infidelity

3. Communicative infidelity

- occurs when people engage in sexual activity with a third party to *communicate a message* to their partner.
- Signal need for attention, means of revenge, message of dissatisfaction

4 types of infidelity

4. Online infidelity

- Romantic or sexual communication facilitated by internet use.
 - Some people do not consider online infidelity to be “real” infidelity.